

Rebuild Your Question

CFAN 3091V | Week 5 Wednesday Workshop

Name: _____ **Date:** _____

Keep this sheet. The rebuilt question goes into Progress Report 2, due Wednesday, October 7.

1. Your Question Now

Write it exactly as you would say it out loud today, however rough.

2. Fill the Slots

Use **one** of the two structures. Leave a slot empty if it is empty. An empty slot is information about your design, not a mistake to hide.

Structure A. Comparison question

Use this when your question compares one thing against another.

Population: who or what is studied, in what system and setting

Intervention or exposure: what exactly is being done or varied

Comparison: what it is measured against, including current practice or no treatment

Outcome: what is measured, in what units, over what period

Structure B. Descriptive, exploratory, or process question

Use this when there is no comparison to make, which is true of most thesis questions in this college.

Population or cases: who or what you are studying, and how those cases are bounded

Phenomenon of interest: the experience, process, practice, or decision you are examining

Context: the setting, system, place, and period that make the cases interpretable

Evidence: what you would collect that would count, such as accounts, observations, documents, or records

3. Rewrite

Write the question again so it contains the slots you filled.

4. Test It Against Three Standards

Answerable. Could you actually collect this evidence, with the time, access, and resources you have?

Specific. Is it detailed enough that someone else could design a study from it without asking you what you meant?

Significant. Who cares, and why? Name someone other than yourself.

5. Partner Test

Trade sheets. Your partner asks the two questions below and writes what they actually heard, not what they think you meant.

Partner name: _____

What would you do to answer this?

If the answer came back the opposite of what you expect, what in your proposal would change?

The inference test

If your partner could not name anything that would change, work out which of these it is:

- ☐ The question is not really open. You already know the answer, so no result would move you.
- ☐ The proposal does not really rest on it. The question is decorative, and the project would proceed unchanged either way.
- ☐ Something else: _____

What you will change as a result:

6. Carry Forward

Your question as it now stands:

The one slot still empty, and what you need before you can fill it:
